



over 1,000 years ago, the Kogi believe their mountain be the “place of creation” and “the heart of the world.” They see themselves as “elder brothers of humanity,” and accept the care of our planet as their sacred

responsibility. A deeply spiritual people, they place great value on communicating with everything around them—including animals, plants, and even rocks—by thought and intuition as well as with words and actions.



GUIDES AND RULERS

The leading figures in Kogi life are called “mamas” (from *mamos* meaning “sun”)—they are always male. Acting as healers, priests, and judges, these figures are chosen from birth. They undergo 18 years of training, much of it spent in caves, where they are deprived of daylight. This mama is holding a *popora*—a hollowed-out gourd used to hold lime powder.

SYMBOLIC BUILDINGS

The construction of Kogi huts is closely linked with the people’s spirituality. For instance, because their belief system states that the universe has nine levels, every roof has nine layers of thatch, which are meticulously laid in alternating directions.



CARRIER BAGS

Kogi women grow cactus fiber, then weave it into bags called *mochilas*.

Worn slung across the chest by the men, these bags hold coca leaves, which are shared with other men as part of the greeting ritual.



SEPARATE LIVES

Kogi families gather in villages when they want to exchange news or make community decisions. When they are there, the men spend much of their time in the *nubue* (“men’s house” or “world house”), the largest and finest building. Even when they are working their land, Kogi families live separately—the men in one hut, and the women and children in another one close by.

